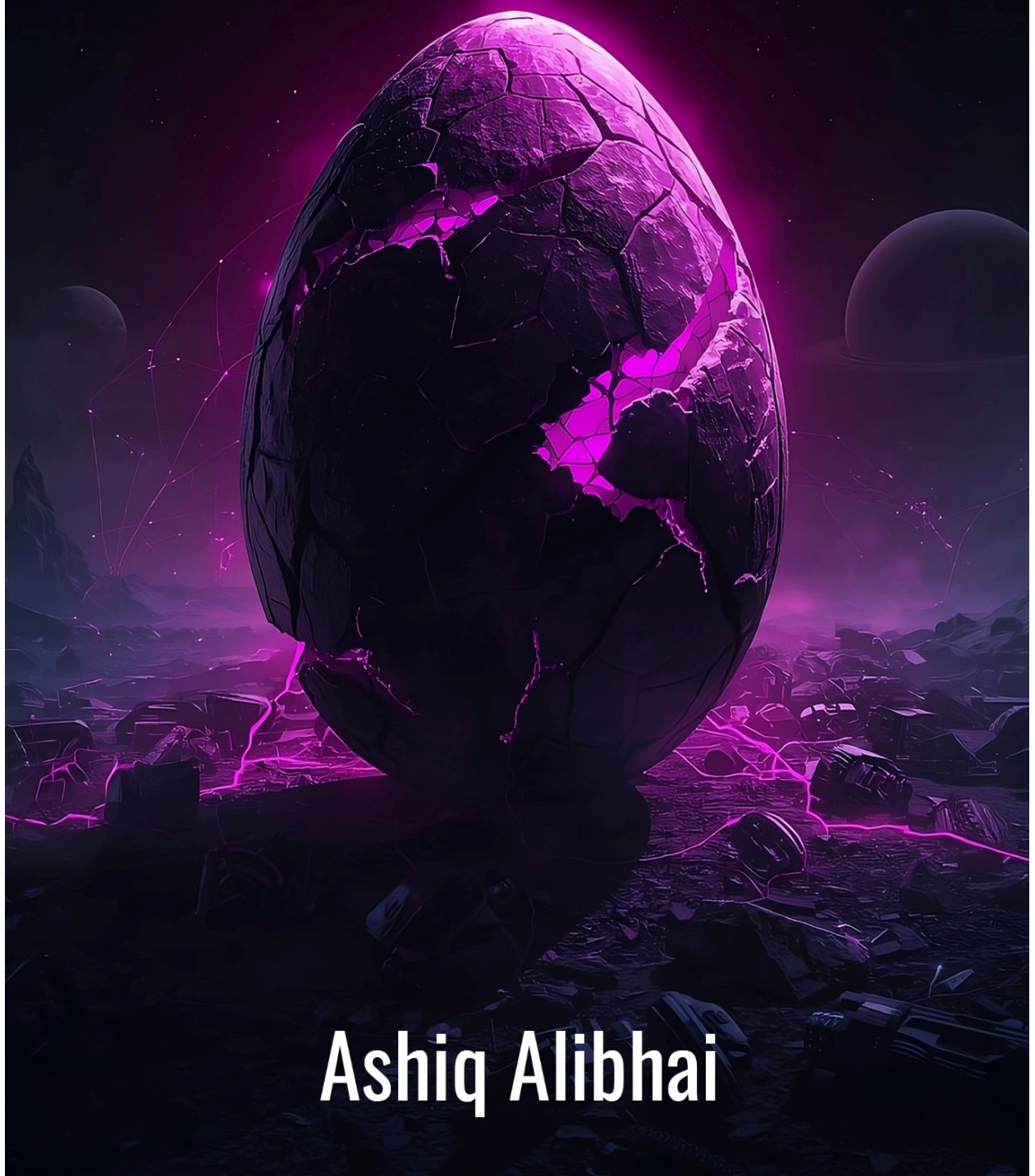


The Coming Swarm

Book One of Starborn Beasts



Ashiq Alibhai

Copyright © 2025 by Ashiq Alibhai.

All rights reserved.

No part of this publication may be reproduced, distributed, or transmitted in any form or by any means, including photocopying, recording, or other electronic or mechanical methods, without the prior written permission of the publisher, except as permitted by U.S. copyright law. For permission requests, contact the authors directly.

The story, all names, characters, and incidents portrayed in this production are fictitious. No identification with actual persons (living or deceased), places, buildings, and products is intended or should be inferred.

Paperback ISBN: 9798232892395

Published by Moonstone Minarets

Prologue: The Ancient Artifact

Em-Ra knew something was wrong with the ruins.

The massive Tromian engineer—a two-meter tall elephant-like humanoid with long dark-grey skin and a powerful, muscular trunk—placed the half-repaired Octolune seal down on the metal bench. She picked her way through the one-room regolith hut that served as her housing on Theta-9, the ninth moon in an unknown system on the edge of the galaxy. Her thick elephant-like feet caused small vibrations in the dust-covered floor.

The communications array blinked steadily in the corner, its soft blue glow the only light in the cramped space aside from the harsh work lamps. Three months until the next supply ship. Three months until anyone would come check on her work. Three months alone with whatever was stirring in the depths below.

Em-Ra's trunk curled reflexively, a nervous habit she'd developed over the past week. The readings were wrong. All of them. The containment seals she'd been reinforcing for the better part of a decade were degrading faster than her models predicted. Much faster.

She pulled up the day's sensor logs on her wrist display, the holographic interface casting pale light across her grey skin. The Engineering L3 suit hummed softly, its integrated systems maintaining comfortable pressure and temperature despite the moon's airless surface above. Tool harnesses crisscrossed her broad chest, each clip holding specialized equipment: plasma welders, molecular adhesive dispensers, diagnostic scanners, emergency patches.

The radiation readings made her pause. Another spike. The third today.

"By the Perfect God," she muttered, her trunk twitching with concern.

Em-Ra expanded the hologram, studying the spectral analysis. The radiation signature was unlike anything in her extensive database—not solar, not cosmic, not from any known reactor design. It pulsed from somewhere deep in the ruins, following a rhythm that her mind kept trying to interpret as biological. But that was impossible. The Korithal had sealed this place millennia ago. Nothing living could survive that long in stasis.

Could it?

She dismissed the display and grabbed her field pack, slinging it across her broad shoulders. The pack settled against her Engineering 3 suit with a familiar weight—emergency oxygen reserves, backup power cells, ration bars she'd barely touched. Her appetite had been declining for days now, ever since the first fuchsia flicker had appeared in the containment chamber.

The airlock cycled with a hiss of pressurization. Em-Ra stepped through into the surface entrance of the ruins, and the true scale of Korithal architecture immediately dwarfed her.

Korithal. She shivered as her thoughts slid to the giant crabs, their crystalline shells reflecting starlight, their eyes glowing like moons. Were they really galaxy shapers, or just another myth?

The entrance chamber stretched fifty meters high, its walls carved from the moon's bedrock with impossible precision. Geometric patterns covered every surface—fractals within fractals, spiraling into mathematical complexity that hurt to observe for too long. Some of the patterns seemed to shift when viewed peripherally, though Em-Ra had long since convinced herself it was an optical illusion created by her work lights.

Mostly convinced herself.

The ancient Korithal light crystals studded the ceiling like dead stars, their translucent surfaces clouded with age. Em-Ra had managed to reactivate exactly three of them in ten years. They'd blazed with brilliant white light for approximately forty seconds before cracking with sounds like breaking glass, leaving only scorched marks on the ancient stone.

She'd stopped trying after the third one.

Her own portable lights cast harsh shadows across the chamber as she made her way to the lift platform. The elevator was a curious hybrid of technology—ancient Korithal gravitic systems that Em-Ra barely understood, reinforced and patched with modern Tromian engineering. It had taken her eight months just to make the thing operational when she'd first arrived.

The control panel responded to her touch, and the platform began its descent with a low hum that echoed strangely in the vast shaft. Em-Ra watched the walls slide past, counting the depth markers she'd installed. One hundred meters. Two hundred. Five hundred.

The temperature dropped as she descended, despite her suit's climate control. At one thousand meters, she passed the first of the warning inscriptions.

The Korithal script covered an entire section of the shaft wall, each character carved a meter deep into the stone. Em-Ra had spent months deciphering it with the help of her linguistic AI, and the translation still sent chills through her massive frame:

**SEALED BY NECESSITY FORGOTTEN BY MERCY
DISTURB NOT THE TOMB OF HUNGER**

Tomb of Hunger. The phrase had haunted her dreams since she'd first translated it. The Korithal had been the greatest civilization in known history, their ruins scattered across a dozen systems, their technology so advanced it seemed like sorcery. They had reshaped planets, built megastructures that defied physics, and then they had vanished, leaving behind only their impossible monuments.

And their warnings.

At fifteen hundred meters, the lift passed the second inscription, this one more urgent:

**THE ETERNAL SLEEP MUST NOT BE BROKEN
WHAT LIES BELOW KNOWS ONLY CONSUMING
GUARD THIS PRISON WITH YOUR LIFE, FOR ALL LIFE DEPENDS UPON IT**

Em-Ra's trunk curled tighter. Every time she read that last line, her resolve wavered. Should she have called for help? Requested a full research team? But the Tromian Science Council had been clear: this was a monitoring station, nothing more. Reinforce the seals, document the decay, and report annually. They had a dozen other Korithal sites with higher priority.

This site was just a curiosity. A footnote. An inconvenience at the edge of known space.

The lift shuddered as it approached three kilometers depth. Here, the Korithal construction changed. The geometric patterns became more organic, almost writhing in the shifting light. The stone itself seemed darker, as if it had absorbed something over the millennia. Em-Ra's geological surveys suggested the rock composition was identical to the surface, but it looked wrong. Felt wrong.

At three thousand meters exactly, the lift stopped.

The containment chamber stretched before her like the throat of some massive beast. The ceiling arched overhead, supported by pillars that seemed to grow organically from the floor. Each pillar was wrapped in concentric rings of metal—Octolune technology, the best shielding money could buy, installed by Em-Ra herself over years of painstaking work.

And every ring was showing signs of stress fractures.

Em-Ra stepped off the lift platform, her heavy footfalls echoing in the chamber. Her breath misted in the cold air despite her suit's thermal regulation. The environmental sensors on her wrist showed minus-fifteen degrees Celsius, impossible given the geothermal activity she'd measured. The energy had to be going somewhere.

She knew where.

At the center of the chamber, surrounded by seven concentric circles of containment technology, sat the vault.

It was a perfect sphere of Korithal crystal, ten meters in diameter, floating precisely one meter above the ground with no visible support. The surface was covered in microscopic script, billions of characters forming equations and warnings and desperate pleas. Em-Ra had scanned less than one percent of it in ten years.

The sphere had been pristine white when she'd first arrived. Now, veins of fuchsia light pulsed beneath its surface like infected blood vessels.

Em-Ra approached slowly, her trunk testing the air as if she could smell the wrongness. Her scanning equipment registered the radiation signature immediately—stronger than this morning's readings, following that same biological rhythm. Pulse. Pulse. Pulse. Like a heartbeat.

The inner containment ring was failing. She'd known it would—that's why she'd come down today, to reinforce the seals before they collapsed entirely. But seeing it in person made her stomachs churn with dread.

The Octolune shielding, which should have been impervious for another century, showed deep cracks running through its metallic surface. The molecular adhesive she'd applied yesterday had already crystallized and begun flaking away. The backup power conduits sparked intermittently, struggling to maintain the stasis field.

"This isn't degradation," Em-Ra said aloud, her voice sounding small in the vast chamber. "This is active corrosion."

She deployed her scanner drone, the small device zipping around the containment rings and feeding data back to her wrist display. The readings confirmed her fears. Whatever was inside the vault was actively breaking down the seals. Not through force, but through some kind of energy emission that destabilized matter at the molecular level.

The Korithal had built this prison to last forever. Someone was waking up inside it.

Em-Ra set to work, her trunk and hands moving with practiced efficiency. She welded new support struts to the damaged sections, applied fresh layers of shielding compound, rerouted power from the backup generators she'd installed on the second containment ring. Hours passed in focused concentration, her world narrowing to the immediate task.

The fuchsia glow grew brighter.

At first, Em-Ra thought it was her imagination, a trick of her work lights reflecting off the crystal. But when she paused to check her progress, she could see it clearly. The veins of light beneath the sphere's surface were spreading, branching like capillaries, pulsing with increasing frequency.

Pulse-pulse. Pulse-pulse. Pulse-pulse.

The rhythm was faster now. Not quite double time, but definitely accelerating.

Em-Ra's trunk trembled. She should leave. Call for help. Evacuate to the surface and seal the lift shaft. Every instinct screamed at her to run, to put as much distance as possible between herself and whatever was inside that vault.

But she was Tromian. Tromians built. Tromians maintained. Tromians held the line.

She moved to the second containment ring, her welder already heating up. If she could just reinforce this section, buy another week, she could send a priority message to the Science Council. They'd have to listen then. They'd have to send help.

The welder's plasma arc blazed blue-white as she fused metal to metal. Sweat matted the skin around her temples despite the cold. The Engineering 3 suit's cooling systems whirled at maximum capacity. Almost done. Just a few more—

The sphere pulsed.

Not the gentle, biological rhythm Em-Ra had observed for the past week. This was different. Violent. The entire vault blazed with fuchsia light so bright she had to shield her eyes. The light didn't just shine—it throbbed with a sound at the edge of hearing, a subsonic vibration that resonated in her bones.

Em-Ra staggered back, her trunk instinctively covering her face. The scanner drone spun erratically before falling from the air, its systems overloaded. Alarms shrieked from every piece of equipment in the chamber. The containment rings sparked and smoked, their shielding pushed far beyond design limits.

Through her splayed fingers, Em-Ra watched the Korithal crystal sphere crack.

It was a single fracture at first, hairline thin, running from the top of the sphere to its equator. Fuchsia light leaked through like luminous blood. The crack spread, branched, multiplied. The sound was worse than breaking glass—it was the sound of breaking reality, as if the universe itself were screaming in protest.

Em-Ra ran.

Her massive body moved with surprising speed, decades of engineering work having kept her fit despite her scholarly nature. The lift platform was twenty meters away. If she could just reach it, seal the shaft, maybe she could contain—

The explosion wasn't heat or force. It was *absence*.

The air itself seemed to retreat from the sphere as the Korithal crystal shattered along one side. Fuchsia light flooded the chamber with the intensity of a newborn star. The containment field flickered, bent, and failed.

Something moved inside the egg. Unseen, unheard, like a pulse against the membrane of space, like a creature dreaming of waking.

Em-Ra caught only impressions: shadows within light, motion within geometry. Her mind rebelled against it. She stumbled back, clutching her temples as equations she had once understood collapsed into nonsense.

Then came the hunger. The idea filled the room like a presence — raw, instinctive need that pressed against her thoughts like a claw.

Em-Ra's breath came short. Her instruments overloaded one by one, alarms screaming in chorus. The Korithal crystal's fracture was widening again, though no force on record should have allowed it.

She turned and sprinted for the lift. Her communicator crackled with static as she tried to broadcast a warning.

"Containment failure—Theta-9 outpost—if anyone hears—"

The light surged, brighter than ever. It swallowed her words.

The shockwave hit — not with fire, but with a cold so deep it froze everything. She was thrown hard against the platform railing, her L3 suit registering catastrophic damage. As she dragged herself upright, she saw the sphere still pulsing behind her — cracked but not open.

For a moment, the light dimmed. The pressure receded.

She activated the emergency ascent. The lift groaned, beginning its slow climb toward the surface.

Through her cracked visor, Em-Ra looked down one last time.

The egg still sat in the wreckage, half-shattered but whole enough to hold whatever nightmare slept within.

From deep inside, something shifted. Not breaking free — just *turning*. A tremor, as if it heard her.

Em-Ra whispered a final prayer and closed her eyes.

At one thousand meters, her hearts failed one by one. The lift continued its ascent, carrying her body toward a surface she never saw again.

Below, the cracked egg pulsed once more. Fuchsia light bled through the fractures, weak but steady.

Waiting.

The preceding was an excerpt of the Coming Swarm. You can purchase the full book, from various vendors, here: <https://ashiqalibhai.com/books/the-coming-swarm.html>